Introduce the session topic. Explain that today's focus is on how we communicate with the public and why clear, respectful communication matters in everyday, workplace, and community interactions.

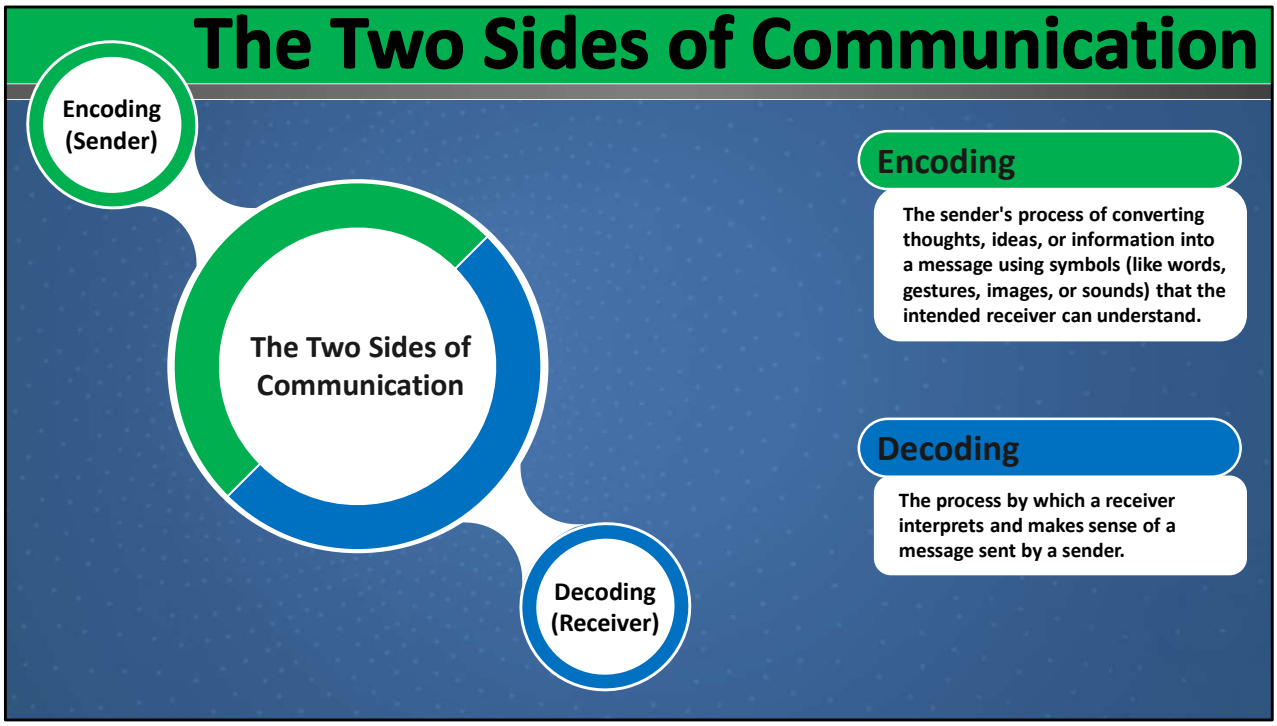
Objectives

- Participate in a listening activity.
- Define communication.
- Explore the elements of communication.
- Compare communication styles
- Discuss the importance of self advocacy.

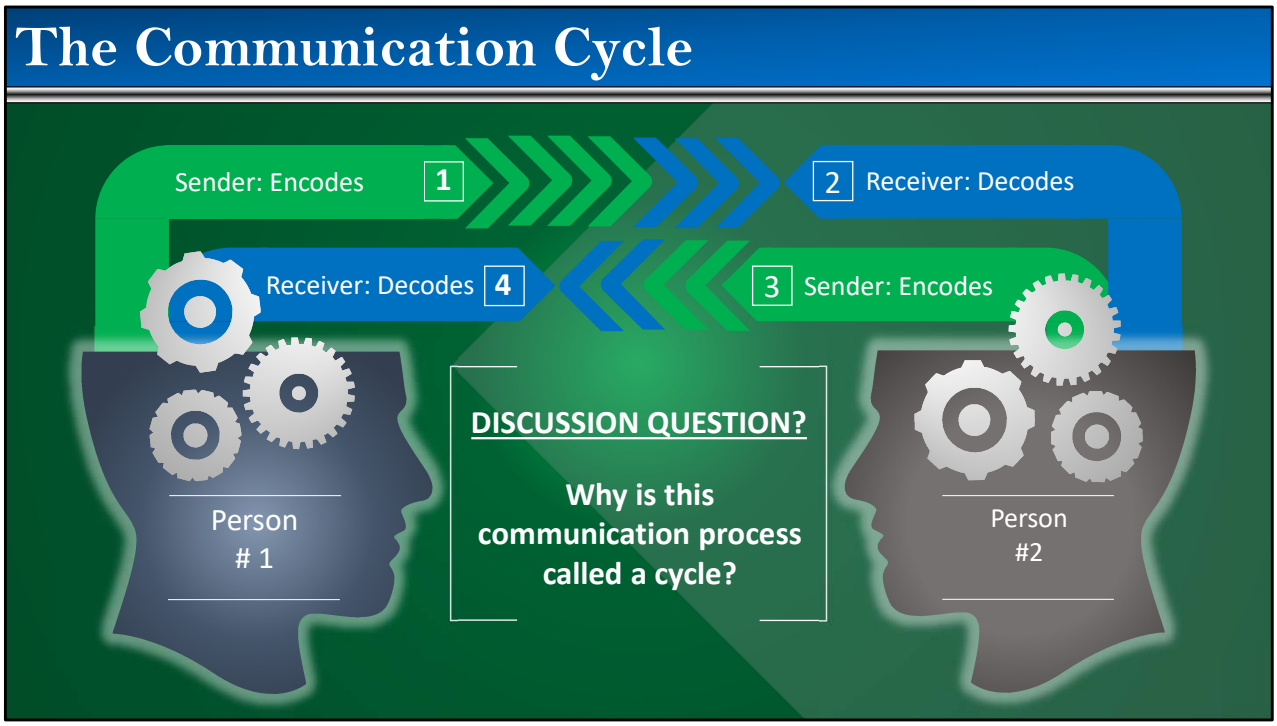
Review the objectives for the session. Let participants know they will practice listening skills, learn what communication really means, explore how messages are sent and received, compare communication styles, and understand the role of self-advocacy.

Explain this warm-up activity. Emphasize that listening can be challenging and that this activity highlights how easily messages can be misunderstood. Encourage participation and reflection.

Define communication clearly. Reinforce that communication includes information, intention, and emotion—not just words. Stress the importance of understanding, not just speaking.

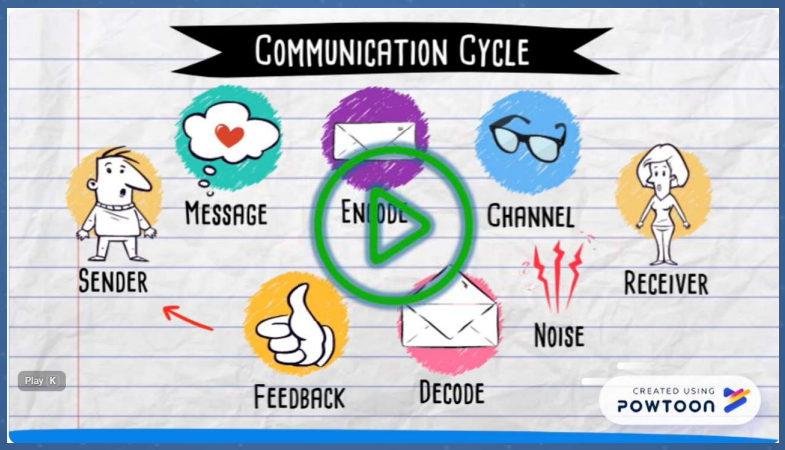


Explain encoding and decoding. Highlight how tone, body language, and word choice affect messages, and how personal experiences influence interpretation.



Describe the communication cycle. Emphasize that communication is ongoing and interactive, with constant feedback between sender and receiver.

The Communication Cycle Video



Prepare participants for the video. Ask them to watch for examples of encoding, decoding, and feedback during the communication process.

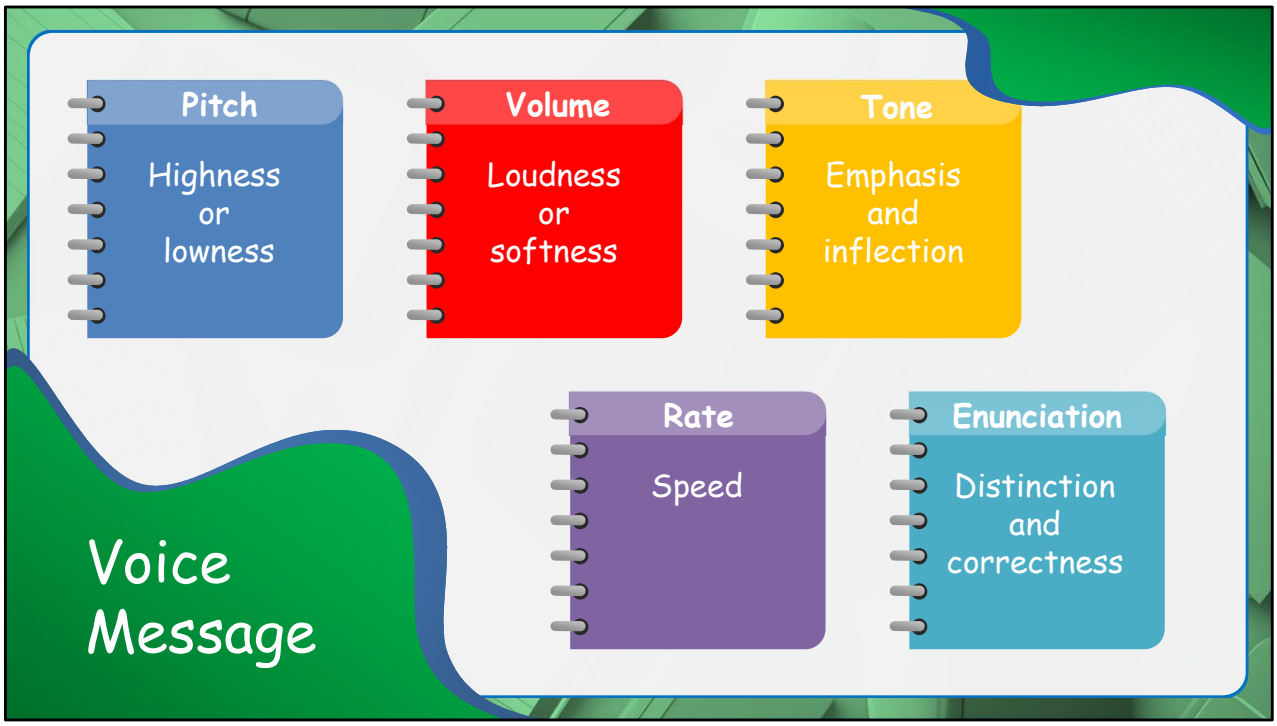
Discuss the difference between hearing and listening. Reinforce that listening requires effort, attention, and intention, and that people may interpret the same message differently.

Review listening skills. Explain attention skills, reflective skills, and the importance of asking clarifying questions to avoid misunderstandings.

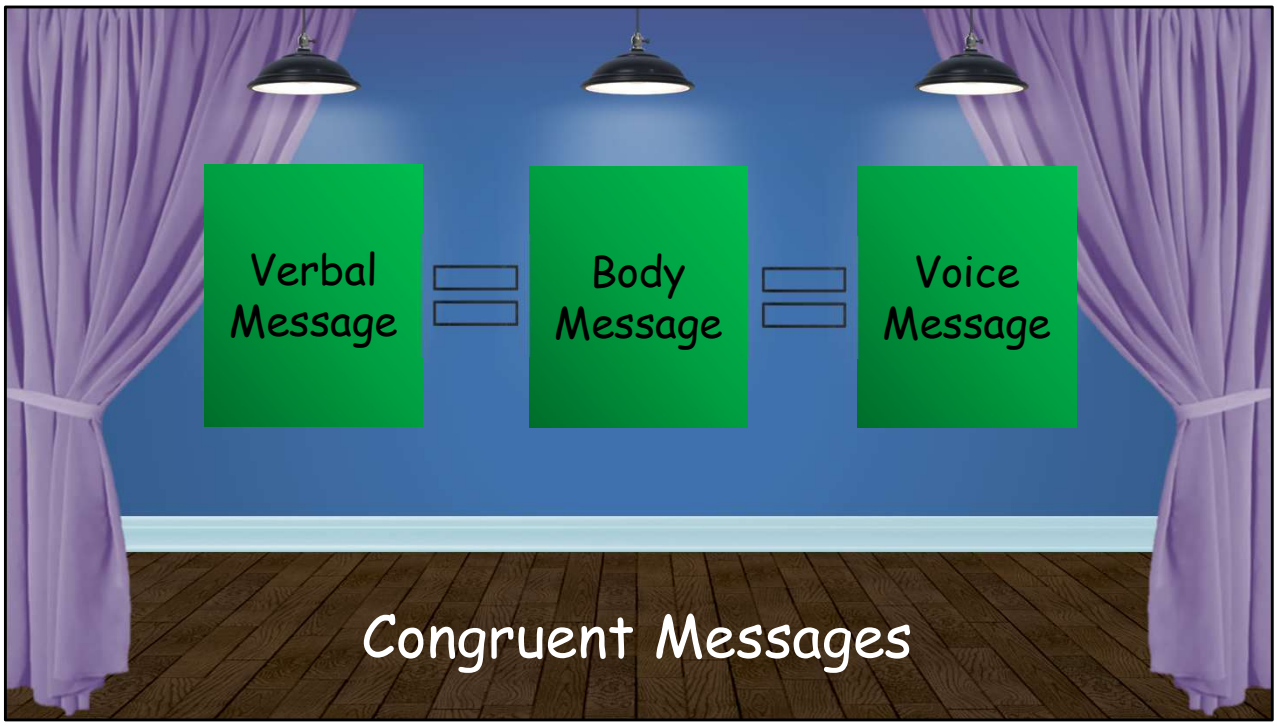
Introduce the three communication styles: verbal, body, and voice. Explain that effective communication depends on all three working together.

Discuss verbal communication. Emphasize proper pronunciation, grammar, appropriate vocabulary, and avoiding slang or swearing in public interactions.

Explain body language. Highlight facial expressions and nonverbal cues, and how they should match the message being delivered.



Discuss voice communication. Explain pitch, volume, tone, rate, and enunciation, and how voice affects how messages are received.



Explain congruent messages. Stress that verbal, body, and voice messages should align to avoid confusion or mistrust.

Introduce self-advocacy. Explain that communicating effectively with the public includes speaking up for yourself respectfully and clearly.

Define self-advocacy. Explain it as the ability to express needs, make informed choices, and seek support when necessary.

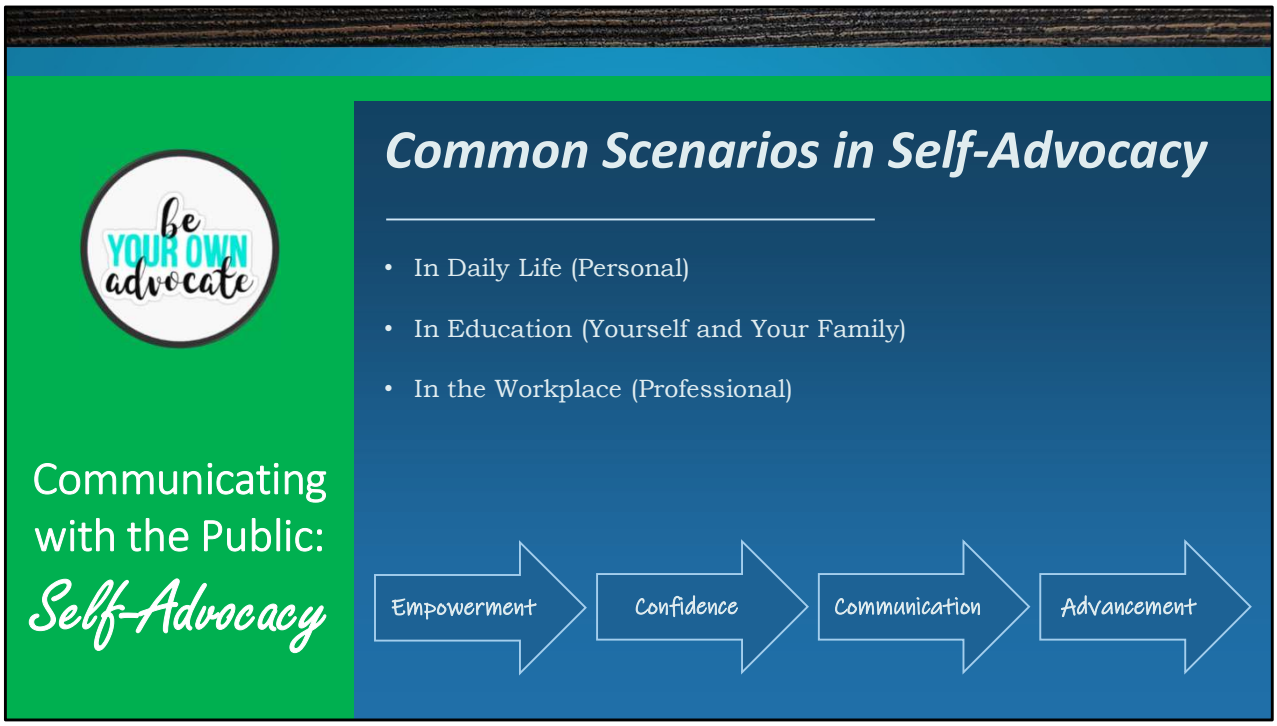
Provide visual examples of self-advocacy. Encourage participants to think about situations where they had to speak up for themselves.

Review examples of self-advocacy in action. Explain each example and connect it to real-life situations.

Explain why self-advocacy matters. Emphasize confidence, empowerment, communication, and personal advancement.

Review key components of self-advocacy, including knowing yourself, knowing your rights, communicating clearly, and setting goals.

Explain how to practice self-advocacy. Encourage use of I-statements, preparation, and respectful persistence.



Discuss common self-advocacy scenarios in daily life, education, and the workplace. Ask participants for examples.

Address barriers to self-advocacy. Normalize fear and lack of confidence, and discuss strategies to overcome them.

Share tips for effective self-advocacy. Emphasize calm communication, positive body language, and patience.

Review available resources for self-advocacy support, including programs, groups, counselors, and community resources.

Explain the self-advocacy cycle. Highlight the importance of documenting, planning, taking action, and reflecting.

Communication is…

Reinforce that communication is ongoing and involves understanding, clarity, and respect in all interactions.

Revisit objectives and summarize key takeaways. Encourage participants to apply listening and self-advocacy skills in real life.